St. Joseph's Anglo-Chinese School
F.5 English Language
Grammar – Lesson 4: Cleft sentences

Name: _____
Class No.: _____
Date: _____

Cleft sentences

Part 1: Proofreading quiz

Each paragraph contains FIVE errors. The errors include **relative clauses**, **inverted patterns** and **parts of speech**. Proofread the paragraphs.

Argument for: Technology has made us lazier. (5 errors) It is claimed that technology makes life easier, but the truth is far less pleasant. Not only teenagers order food instead of cooking, but they also replace real conversations with emoji-filled messages. They sit for hours on apps, that were designed to save time, and end up achieving nothing meaningful. The convenient of instant delivery has destroyed any reason to walk to the shops. Rarely parents notice that their children have forgotten how to hold a proper conversation. Only by encouraging teenagers to put down their phones the family can have a real conversation.
Argument against: Technology has made us lazier. (5 errors) Critics argue that technology has destroyed our generation. Nevertheless, the truth is that adults have simply misunderstood how we work. What they refuse to accept is that digital tools have allowed young people to accomplish more than the previous generation, for who technology was not available. The believe that real work must involve physical sweat ignores the fact that running a website demands just as much effort. Seldom critics acknowledge that a teenager editing videos is working just as hard as someone lifting boxes. The reason why teenagers seem distracted is not lazy but the creative work they are doing on their phones. Only when adults look at the results of their work they can understand what teenagers actually achieve.

Teacher's answers

1A. Not only do teenagers order food instead of cooking... (Move 'do' before the subject — 'Not only' inverts.)

2A. They sit for hours on apps, which were designed to save time... ('that' cannot be used after a comma in a non-restrictive clause; use 'which'.)

3A. The convenience of instant delivery has destroyed any reason to walk to the shops. ('convenient' → 'convenience' — a noun is needed after 'the'.)

4A. Rarely do parents notice that their children have forgotten how to hold a proper conversation. (Move 'do' before the subject — 'Rarely' inverts.)

5A. Only by encouraging teenagers to put down their phones can the family have a real conversation. (Move 'can' before the subject — 'Only by' inverts.)

1B. ...for whom technology was not available. ('who' → 'whom' — the object form of the relative pronoun is needed after a preposition.)

2B. The belief that real work must involve physical sweat ignores the fact... ('believe' → 'belief' — a noun is needed after 'the'.)

3B. Seldom do critics acknowledge that a teenager editing videos... (Move 'do' before the subject — 'Seldom' inverts.)

4B. The reason why teenagers seem distracted is not laziness but the creative work... ('lazy' → 'laziness' — a noun is needed after 'not'.)

5B. Only when adults look at the results of their work can they understand... (Move 'can' before the subject — 'Only when' inverts.)

Part 2: Cleft sentences in formal writing

1. Why Use Cleft Sentences in DSE Writing?

> Cleft sentences (splitting a sentence into two clauses) allow you to **emphasize** critical arguments in essays, speech writings, or articles. They help to make your arguments more **persuasive.**

2. Key Cleft Sentence Structures

Type	Formula / Pattern	DSE Tech Example
It-Cleft	**It + is/was** + [Focused Element] + **that/who**...	**Original:** Social media addiction erodes face-to-face social skills among teens. It is **social media addiction** that erodes face-to-face social skills among teens. It is **face-to-face social skills** that social media addiction erodes among teens. It is **among teens** that social media addiction erodes face-to-face social skills.
Wh-Cleft	**What** [Clause] + **is/are** + [Focused Element]	Original: Young people need most today is a digital detox from constant notifications.

		What young people need most today is a **digital detox from constant notifications**. What young people need to do most today is **take a digital detox from constant notifications.** Those/The ones who need a digital detox most today **are young people.**
All-Cleft	**All** [that] [Clause] + **is/are** + [Focused Element]	**Original:** Algorithms only care about maximising user engagement. All (that) algorithms care about is **maximising user engagement.** All (that) algorithms do is **maximise user engagement.**

Teacher's reference: Popular Culture Examples

It-cleft examples from popular culture:

• "It is not the strength of the body, but the strength of the spirit that counts." (The Lord of the Rings)

• "It is not our abilities that show what we truly are. It is our choices." (Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets)

• "It was the best of times, it was the worst of times." (Charles Dickens, A Tale of Two Cities)

Wh-cleft examples from popular culture:

• "What doesn't kill you makes you stronger." (Kelly Clarkson / Nietzsche)

• "What we do in life echoes in eternity." (Gladiator)

• "What the world needs now is love, sweet love." (Burt Bacharach / Jackie DeShannon)

All-cleft examples from popular culture:

• "All I want for Christmas is you." (Mariah Carey) — All [that] I want for Christmas is you.

• "All we have to decide is what to do with the time that is given us." (Gandalf, The Lord of the Rings)

• "All that glitters is not gold." (Shakespeare / J.R.R. Tolkien)

3. Practice Sets - Part A: Form It-Clefts

*Rewrite each sentence as an **It-Cleft**.*

1. The proliferation of smartphones has altered interpersonal communication patterns. [Focus on the proliferation of smartphones]

It is the proliferation of smartphones that has altered interpersonal communication patterns.

2. Tech companies prioritize profit over user privacy in the digital age. [Focus on the profit]

It is profit that tech companies prioritize over user privacy in the digital age.

3. Gen Z teenagers spend most of their leisure hours on short-form video apps. [Focus on the apps]

It is short-form video apps that Gen Z teenagers spend most of their leisure hours on.

4. Generative AI tools created widespread concern among secondary educators last year. [Focus on the AI tools]

It was generative AI tools that created widespread concern among secondary educators last year.

5. Online anonymity encourages cyberbullies to post malicious comments. [Focus on the anonymity]

It is online anonymity that encourages cyberbullies to post malicious comments.

Part B: Form Wh-Clefts / All-Clefts

*Instructions: Rewrite each sentence as a **Wh-cleft / an All-cleft**.*

1. Excessive screen time damages sleep quality and mental well-being. [Wh-cleft: Focus on what damages sleep quality...]

What damages sleep quality and mental well-being is excessive screen time.

2. The government should regulate misleading targeted advertisements on social media. [Wh-left: Focus on what the government should do...]

What the government should do is regulate misleading targeted advertisements on social media.

3. Modern teenagers desire instant validation through likes and comments. [Wh-cleft: Focus on who desires instance validation..]

Those who desire instant validation through likes and comments are modern teenagers.

4. Social media platforms aim to keep users scrolling as long as possible [All-cleft: Focus on what social media platforms aim to do..]

All (that) social media platforms aim to do is keep users scrolling as long as possible.

5. Cyberbullies hide behind anonymous profile pictures to cause harm. [Focus on what cyberbullies do...]

What cyberbullies do is hide behind anonymous profile pictures to cause harm.

Part C: DSE Proofreading & Sentence Transformation (Paragraph Context)

Instructions: Read the student essay draft excerpt below. Rewrite the underlined plain sentences into cleft sentences (It-cleft, Wh-cleft, or All-cleft) to enhance emphasis and argument structure.

> **Student Writing Draft (HKDSE Essay - Topic: Digital Well-being)**
>
> While digital platforms promise seamless connectivity across global boundaries, many sociologists argue that hyper-connectivity actually breeds unprecedented emotional isolation. (1) **Standard messaging apps lack genuine emotional warmth**. As a result, online interactions often feel superficial, leaving young people feeling increasingly isolated despite being constantly reached by peers. To address this growing digital crisis, measures like banning mobile phones in schools are inadequate and fail to address the root cause. (2) **Schools need critical digital literacy education, not total phone bans**. Furthermore, tech monopolies intentionally design algorithms to keep users hooked for as long as possible. (3) **Social media algorithms only care about financial profit**. Ultimately, technology itself is neither inherently good nor evil; the key lies in how mindfully we choose to navigate the digital realm. (4) **Users require a conscious boundaries setting to regain control over their time**.

Sample transformations:

(1) **It is standard messaging apps that lack genuine emotional warmth. // What standard messaging apps lack is genuine warmth.**

(2) **What schools need is critical digital literacy education, not total phone bans. // It is critical digital literacy education that schools need, not total phone bans.**

(3) **All that social media algorithms care about is financial profit.**

(4): **What users require is a conscious boundaries setting to regain control over their time. //All users require is a conscious boundaries setting to regain control over their time.**